

Survey Wording Experiment Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 25-30 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	25-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	survey-wording-experiment

Big idea: Measuring beliefs can alter the result.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Two versions of the same question using 'support' versus 'allow'. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A neutral, loaded, and leading survey item on the same issue. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Survey Wording Experiment Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A class comparison chart showing how wording shifts results. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Measuring beliefs can alter the result.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Can surveys measure beliefs objectively?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Two versions of the same question using 'support' versus 'allow'.
- A neutral, loaded, and leading survey item on the same issue.
- A class comparison chart showing how wording shifts results.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Human Sciences.

Activity Steps

- 1. Half the class receives: "Should students be allowed to use AI to support learning?"
- 2. The other half receives: "Should students be allowed to use AI to complete schoolwork?"
- 3. Compare results.
- 4. Students redesign the question to reduce bias.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Can surveys measure beliefs objectively?
- How does wording shape data?
- Are human sciences less certain, or differently certain?

Knowledge Questions

- Can surveys measure beliefs objectively?
- How does wording shape data?
- Are human sciences less certain, or differently certain?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with two versions of the same question using 'support' versus 'allow'. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...